6 Emergence of Indian Nationalism

"The period from 1858 to 1905 was the seed time of Indian nationalism; the early nationalists sowed the seeds well and deep."
— ***Bipan Chandra***

Rise of Indian Nationalism and Factors Responsible

Indian nationalism was a significant and transformative response to British colonial rule. It marked a crucial phase in India's struggle for independence and played a pivotal role in shaping the country's destiny. Indian nationalism began in the late 19th century and grew throughout the early 20th century.

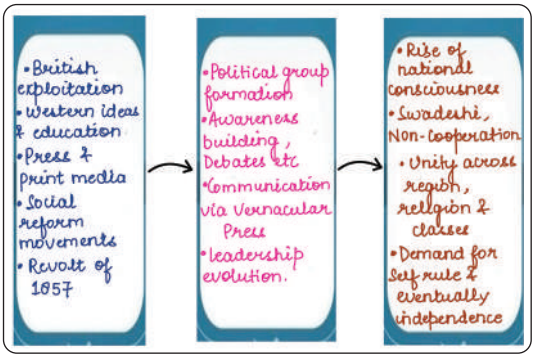

Fig. 6.1: Emergence of Indian Nationalism
Diagram Type: *Input Process Output*

Causes of Rise of Nationalism in India

The rise of Indian nationalism can be attributed to several factors that have shaped the country's history and political landscape.

Here are some key factors responsible for the rise of Indian nationalism: (UPSC 2019)

1. **Cultural Revival and Rediscovery of India's Past**
   - Cultural renaissance led by scholars and reformers like R.G. Bhandarkar and Swami Vivekanand revived pride in India's history, traditions, and heritage.
   - European Indologists like Max Muller linked Indo-Aryans with Europeans, boosting Indian self-esteem.
   - Nationalists countered colonial narratives, promoting a proud cultural identity.
2. **Impact of Western Education and Political Ideas**
   - English education enabled pan-Indian communication among leaders.
   - Exposure to liberalism and democracy in Britain inspired comparisons with India's political denial of rights.
   - Educated professionals—lawyers, doctors, civil servants—emerged as opinion leaders.
3. **Socio-Religious Reform Movements**
   - Movements like Arya Samaj, Ramakrishna Mission, and Singh Sabha revived traditions and fought social evils.
   - Promoted national identity, cultural pride, and unity across religious and regional lines.
4. **Growth of Middle Class and Pre-Congress Organisations**
   - Western-educated elite from groups like Bengal's Bhadralok and Bombay's Chitpavan Brahmins became key nationalist voices.
   - Regional associations before the INC demanded Indian self-rule and governance.
   - Emphasised all-India goals and modern concepts of sovereignty.
5. **Role of Press, Vernacular Literature, and Modern Communication**
   - Newspapers criticised colonial policies and demanded rights, liberty, and reforms.
   - Literature like *Anandamath*, *Nil Darpan*, and *Bharat Durdasa* stirred anti-British sentiment.
   - Railways, telegraphs, and travel united leaders and spread ideas rapidly.
6. **British Policies and Cultural/Economic Exploitation**
   - Conservative policies like the Vernacular Press Act, Arms Act, and Ilbert Bill controversy highlighted British bias.
   - British institutions suppressed Indian languages, values, and traditions, fuelling cultural resistance.
   - Dada Bhai Naoroji's *Drain Theory* exposed British economic exploitation post-Industrial Revolution.

These elements promoted nationalism. Indians received a new spirit. They awoke and joined the freedom fight. British rule was ending. The Indian National Congress's 1885 founding accelerated it.

Early Political Organisations in India and their Achievements

The Indian National Congress (INC) spearheaded a victorious political struggle during the Indian Freedom Struggle. **However, Congress was not the First Political Association**. Political rights associations existed before Congress.

Need for Creating Political Organisations

Colonial India's unique circumstances led to the formation of political organizations. Key reasons include:

1. **Colonial Resistance**: These organizations aimed to end British rule, formed in response to oppressive policies, economic exploitation, and the denial of political and social rights.
2. **Nationalism and Identity**: They fostered Indian nationalism, uniting diverse communities and promoting national unity and pride in a free India.
3. **Representation and Advocacy**: Political organizations provided a platform for Indians to voice grievances, demand rights, and push for participation in governance. They also challenged discriminatory colonial policies and sought social equality.
4. **Policy Formulation and Planning**: These groups shaped India's future by formulating political ideologies and post-colonial visions. They facilitated debates on socio-political issues, influencing the independence movement and post-independence governance.
5. **Mass Mobilization and Public Awareness**: Political organizations aimed to mobilize the masses, raise awareness about colonial injustices, and organize protests, meetings, and movements to support independence.
6. **International Support and Solidarity**: They built alliances with global anti-colonial movements to pressure the British and gain international support for India's independence.

The Indian National Congress, among others, played a crucial role in shaping the independence movement, leading to India's independence in 1947.

Political Institutions before Indian National Congress

- Raja Ram Mohan Roy, Bengal's first political activist, was influenced by Western ideas and drew British attention to Indian issues. He is credited with influencing several liberal provisions in the Charter Act of 1833. However, his associates formed Bengal's first political organisation, the Bangabhasha Prakasika Sabha, in 1836.

Political Organisation	Description
Bangabhasha Prakasika Sabha (1836)	❖ Associate of Raja Ram Mohan Rai, Prasanna Kr. Thakur, Kalinath Chowdhury, Dwarakanath Tagore, and others created the Bangabhasa Prakasika Sabha in 1836. They were advocating for Indians in higher government positions, press freedom, and Ryots' Zamindari persecution.
Zamindari Association	❖ Dwarkanath Tagore established the Zamindari Association, also known as the **"Landholders Association"**, in March 1838 to safeguard landlords' interests. ❖ **The Zamindari Association was India's first political organisation.** ❖ For its goals, it was the **first to use constitutional demonstration.**
British India Society	❖ **Formation:** The British Indian Society was formed in 1851 through the merger of the Zamindari Association and the Bengal British India Society. ❖ **Methods & Demands:** It petitioned the British Parliament, seeking a separate legislature with populist aims and removal of taxes like salt, excise, and postage. ❖ **Outcome:** In 1853, the Governor-General's Legislative Council was expanded by six members.
Indian Association of Calcutta	❖ **Formation and Founders:** The Indian Association of Calcutta was established in 1876 by Surendranath Banerjee and Ananda Mohan Bose, replacing Sisir Kumar Ghosh's Indian League (1875), to promote nationalism and political awareness. ❖ **Objectives and Outreach:** Aimed to unite Indians under a political programme, build mass political support, and include low-income members through nominal fees. It also expanded through Bengali and non-Bengali branches. ❖ **Key Contributions:** Gained prominence during the Ilbert Bill controversy (1883) and held the first session of the 'All India National Conference' in Calcutta the same year.

Factors for the Limited Success of Pre-Congress Organisations

- **Lack of Unity:** Early Indian political parties struggled to retain unity. Disintegration, clashing ideologies, and personal conflicts often reduced their political impact.
- **Limited Support Base**: These organisations struggled to fight British colonial control without substantial grassroots support.
- **British repression**: The British colonial authority quickly suppressed political activity deemed a threat to their control.
- **Early political organisations lacked effective methods and goals**. They struggled to gain support because they concentrated on local issues or didn't present a comprehensive vision for India's independence.
- **Communication Challenges**: Political organisations have trouble mobilising and coordinating throughout the vast and diverse Indian subcontinent due to poor communication infrastructure.

While many political organisations before the Indian National Congress failed to achieve their goals, they set the framework for future movements and grew nationalist consciousness in India. The 1885-founded Indian National Congress helped India gain independence.

Foundation of Indian National Congress

Factors Leading to the Foundation of Congress

- **Political Awakening of Masses**: The founding of the Indian National Congress in 1885 was not a historical accident.
  - It was the culmination of a political awakening that started in the 1860s and 1870s and accelerated in the late 1870s and early 1880s.
- **A.O. Hume's Initiative**: British civil officer Allan Octavian Hume recognised the need for a political conversation and representation platform and founded the Indian National Congress. In 1885, **Hume convened the Congress and became its general secretary.** Indian National Congress organised it first session Gokuldas Tejpal Sanskrit College in Bambay in December 1885 presided by Womesh Chandra Bannerjee and attended by 72 delegates.
- **Moderates and Early Leadership:** These politicians promoted constitutional reforms, peaceful means, and Indian interests within the British colonial framework.
- **Demands for Reforms**: The Indian National Congress initially sought increased representation for Indians in the administration, civil services, and legislative councils under the British colonial government.
- **Mass Mobilisation**: To establish a broader movement against British rule, the party engaged with common people, workers, peasants, and others.

Safety Valve Theory and Congress

- **Origin of safety valve theory**: The safety valve theory is attributed to Lord Dufferin, Viceroy of India from 1884 to 1888.
  - Historian argued that by providing political outlets like the Indian National Congress, the British could channel and regulate Indian nationalism and prevent extreme and revolutionary movements.
- **Historical proof:** William Wedderburn's biography of A.O. Hume inspired the 7 volumes of secret reports.
  - The Safety Valve Theory of Congress creation cites **A.O. Hume's possession of 7 volumes of confidential reports in Shimla** that warned of boiling unrest in Indian society.
- **Sir Valentine Chirol's 1910 book "Indian Unrest" expanded on the safety valve notion.**
  - Chirol claimed that the British fostered the Indian National Congress to relieve political pressure and avert more serious challenges to their power.
- **In 1916's Young India, Extremist leader Lala Lajpat Rai attacked Congress** Moderates with the safety-valve doctrine.
- R. Palme Dutt's authoritative work, India Today, further strengthened this theory.

Why is the Safety Valve Theory Refuted?

- **No Historical Evidence**: The seven-volume secret report was never found in physical form.
- **Challenge to British Control**: In its later years, Congress directly challenged British authority, demanding political reforms, contradicting the idea that it was controlled opposition.
- **Rise of Radical and Revolutionary Groups**: Terrorists and militant nationalists sought independence through direct, violent means, proving that Congress was not the only outlet for nationalist sentiments.
- **Grassroots Mobilisation**: The Safety Valve theory claimed Congress was a top-down British organization. In reality, Congress became a platform for Indians to express aspirations for self-rule, shaping nationalist sentiments.
- **Repressive British Methods**: British authorities used repressive tactics against nationalist movements, including Congress. Dufferin and his allies even declared, "We cannot allow Congress to exist." Congress's shift from reform to independence showed its role was more than just a safety valve.

These points refute the Safety Valve theory, demonstrating that Congress was a more complex, grassroots movement instrumental in India's independence

Aim and Objectives of Congress

- **As per Bipin Chandra, Congress has two basic objectives.** Other objectives revolve around two basic ones -
  - To foster **nation-building** and **Indian identity.**
  - To provide a single political programme or platform for political workers across India to assemble and mobilise people.
- The first president of the Indian National Congress, Womesh Chandra Banerjee, set three goals:

1. **Strengthening national unity**. For this, Congress sessions were held nationwide. Presidents from various regions presided over these sessions.
2. **To reach out to all religions and alleviate minority worries**. In the 1888 session, if a majority of Hindus or Muslims opposed a resolution, it would not pass.

3. **Congress was resolved to construct a secular nation.** The Congress was fiercely secular for this.

- **Social reform was off-limits to Congress**. Dada Bhai Naoroji made this explicit in his presidential address to the 2nd Congress. He believes Congress should only address national issues.

Weaknesses of Congress in its Early Phase

- **Elite Leadership:** The early Congress was predominantly led by English-educated, upper-class individuals like Dadabhai Naoroji and Surendranath Banerjee. This limited its appeal to the broader Indian masses who were predominantly rural and underprivileged.
- **Moderate Methods:** The early strategies of Congress were characterized by petitions, resolutions, and discussions, often referred to as the "politics of mendicancy." This moderate approach was criticized for being too passive and ineffective against the aggressive policies of the British.
- **Lack of Mass Involvement**: Initial movements and activities were largely confined to the urban elites, with little effort made to involve the vast rural population who formed the majority of India's demographic.
- **Regional Imbalance:** The Congress leadership and activities were predominantly centered in a few regions like Bombay, Calcutta, and Madras, leading to uneven representation and participation across the diverse geographic and cultural landscape of India.
- **Slow to Address Social Issues:** In its early years, Congress was cautious in addressing radical social reforms, focusing primarily on political and administrative issues. This approach often alienated socially marginalized groups who were affected by pressing issues like caste discrimination and untouchability.
- **Communication Gaps:** The use of English as the primary language for Congress proceedings and communications excluded a large part of the population who were not versed in English, thereby limiting wider engagement and understanding.

Despite its limitations, it marked a modernisation of Indian politics by promoting national unity and making a crucial political demand: "The basis of the government should be widened, and the people should have their proper and legitimate share in it."

Approaches and Limitations of Moderate Phase (1885 -1905)

Methods Adopted by Moderates

- **Prayer and Petition:** Moderates used respectful language in resolutions, opting to "suggest" rather than "demand." Critics later mocked this as lacking self-respect.
- **Voice of the People:** Petitions were framed in the name of the Indian people, aiming to involve them in governance and legitimize their stake in the system.
- **Economic Critique of Colonialism:** Leaders like Dadabhai Naoroji and R.C. Dutt highlighted issues like poverty, economic drain, and de-industrialization under British rule through research and publications.

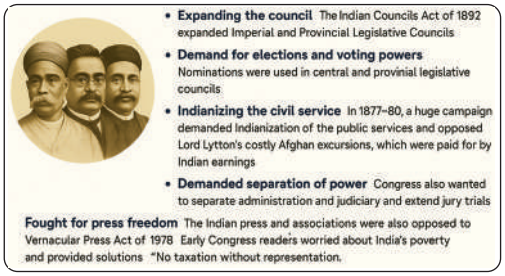

Fig. 6.2: Demands of Moderates and Success Achieved

- **Public Engagement:** They organized meetings and conferences to educate and mobilize public opinion on national issues.
- **Press and Publications:** Journals, newspapers, and pamphlets were key tools to spread awareness and critique colonial policies.
- **Strategic Cooperation:** Moderates engaged with sympathetic British officials and used legislative councils to highlight grievances and push for reforms.
- **Education and International Advocacy:** They promoted education to empower citizens and took India's cause to global forums to garner international support.

Limitations of Moderates (UPSC 2017)

- **Limited Objectives**: The Moderates mainly aimed for administrative reforms, fair representation, and greater Indian participation in governance without demanding full independence. They sought minor concessions, like more Indian representation in services and councils, which later nationalists saw as inadequate.
- **Conservative Methods**: They relied on petitions, speeches, and writings, which were considered too passive and ineffective against British imperial policies, requiring more assertive action.
- **Narrow Social Base**: The leaders, mostly from the educated elite and upper-middle class, failed to connect with the broader Indian masses, including the poor and underprivileged. Figures like Dadabhai Naoroji and Gopal Krishna Gokhale were seen as distant from the average Indian peasant or worker.
- **Lack of Aggressive Leadership**: The Moderates' polite, loyal approach was criticized for being weak, especially when British authorities ignored or dismissed their demands. The British used this soft stance to implement reforms at their discretion.

- **Failure to Address Broader Social Issues**: They focused mainly on political and administrative reforms, neglecting social issues like caste discrimination, poverty, and mass education, limiting their impact on India's social fabric.
- **Underestimation of Colonial Intentions**: The Moderates believed in the possibility of a fair British administration, which clashed with the reality of British colonial interests focused on control and exploitation.

Conclusion

Moderates were flawed but accomplished. They formed nationalist movements, educated Indians, and shaped the Indian National Congress. Later Indian freedom struggles were radicalised by the moderates' constraints.

Key Words

Rise of Indian nationalism, Socio-religious movements, Western education, Emergence of middle class, Use of press, British administrative policies, Economic exploitation, Cultural suppression.

	Previous Year Questions	Year
1.	To what extinct did the role of moderates prepare a base for the wider freedom movement? Comment.	2021
2.	Examine the linkages between the nineteenth century's 'Indian Renaissance' and the emergence of national identity.	2019
3.	Why did the 'Moderates' fail to carry conviction with the nation about their proclaimed ideology and political goals by the end of the nineteenth century?	2017